Music in Western Civilization

Topic 2.2

The Medieval Period

(The Middles Ages)

中世纪

500-1500 AD

Professor Chan Wing Wah
陈永华教授

January 2026

Medieval architecture: from Romanesque to Gothic

- **Romanesque** 罗马式, 11th-12th century:
- following the Roman and Byzantine style, massive, thick walls, *round arches*, stone and marble, cylindrical tower, vault, symmetrical
- https://www.google.com/search?q=romanesque+architecture&sca_esv=600366984&tbm=isch&source=lnms&sa=X&ved=2ahUKEwi3_LHJ0vCDAxWEbPUHHcy_AGwQ_AUoAXoECAIQAw&biw=1283&bih=553&dpr=1.5
- **Gothic** 哥特式, 12th-16th century:
- *Long pointed arch*, vertical proportion, flying external buttressing, more elaborate stained-glass
- windows, ribbed vaults

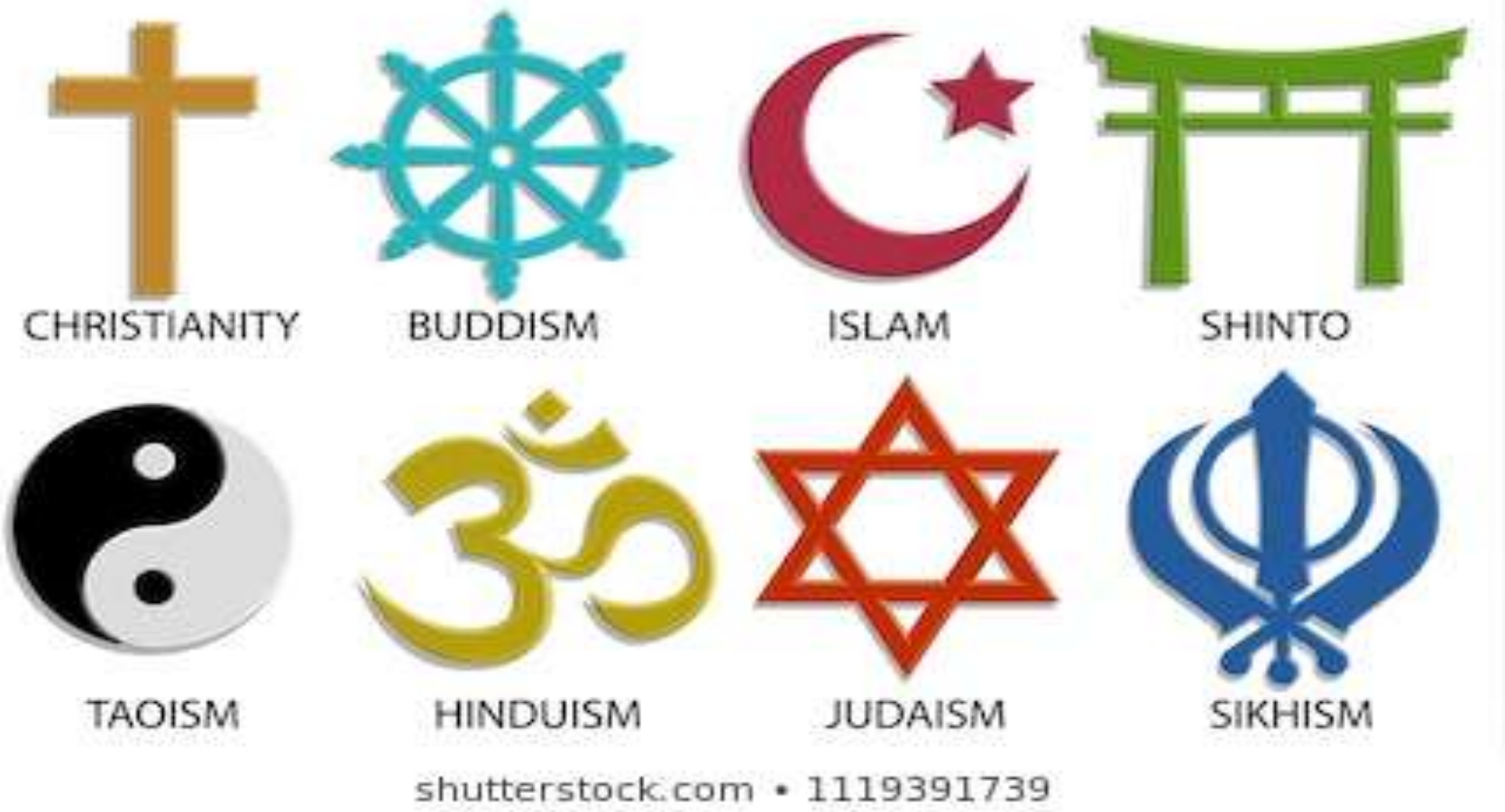




Medieval Period（The Middle Ages)

c. 500-1500 AD

- ***Architecture***: (Eastern Roman Empire)*Byzantine* 拜占庭帝国 (330-1453 AD) domes, the cylindrical *Romanesque*罗马式 and the tall *Gothic*哥特式 buildings mostly churches.
- ***Art***: Early Christian & Roman art, Byzantine *mosaics*, Romanesque and Gothic art.
- ***Music***: sacred: chant, organum, **Mass/Missa弥撒曲**; secular: songs and dances;
- ***Religion***: Roman Catholic 罗马天主教, Byzantine Orthodox拜占庭东正教, Zoroastrian祆教，拜火教(founder Zarathustra around 1,500 BC, as a recorded religion from 6th century BC) , Islam (from 6th century AD).
- ***The Travels of Marco Polo***: a 13th-century travelogue written down by Rustichello da Pisa from stories told by Italian explorer Marco Polo (1254-1324 Venetian)



Zoroastrian 祆教，拜火教



Greek & Roman pillars



Doric



Ionic



Corinthian







Medieval architecture :

Romanesque 罗马式

(6th)-11th-12th century

- Semi-circular arches, massive quality, big walls, stone,



The Mosque of Ibn Tulun, Cairo, Egypt (876-9 AD)



The Mosque of Ibn Tulun,

Cairo, Egypt
(876-9 AD)



Sultan Ahmed 'Blue' Mosque, Istanbul, Turkey 1609-1616
with six minarets宣礼塔

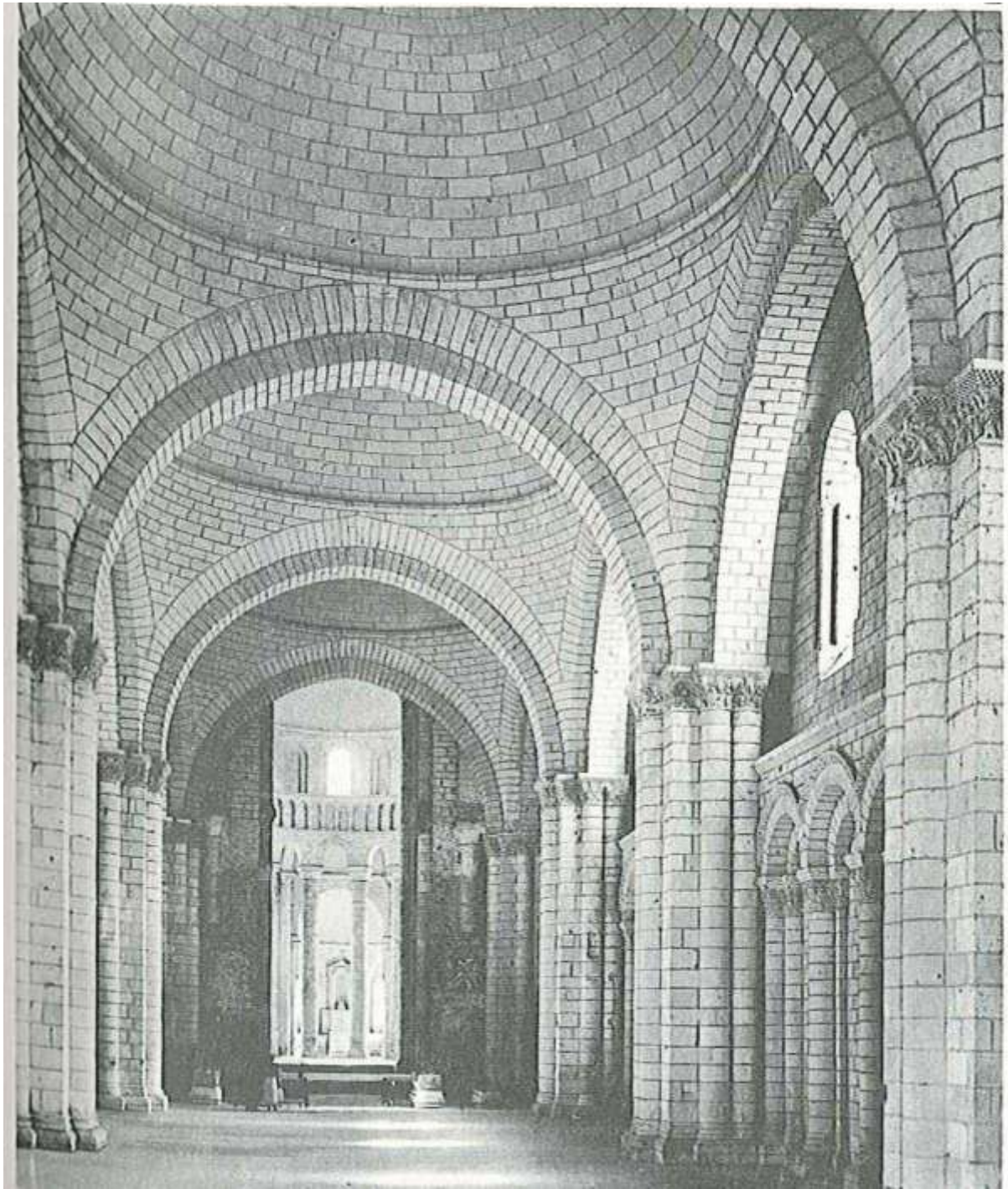




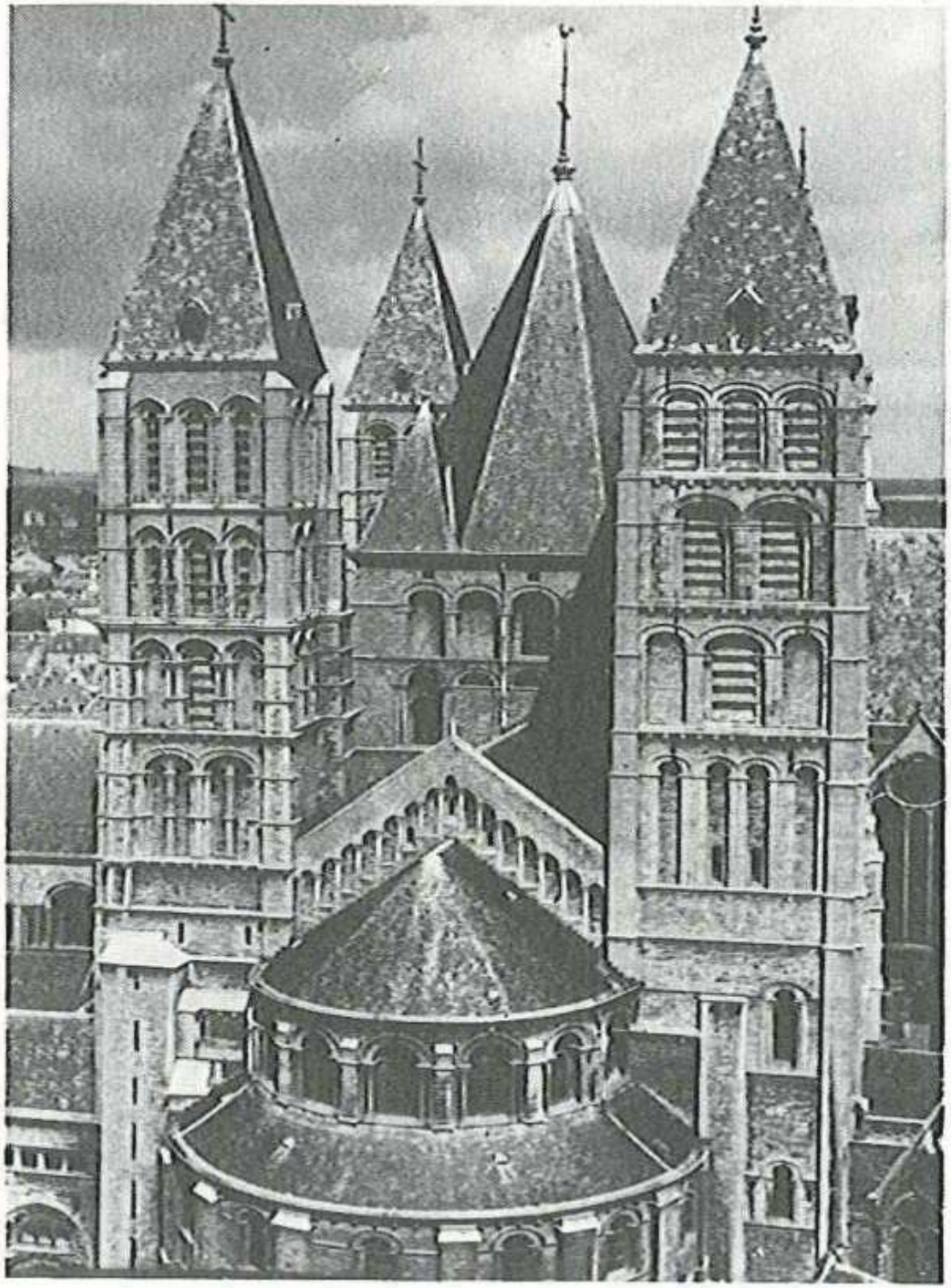
Church of San Martin, on the way to Santiago de Compostela



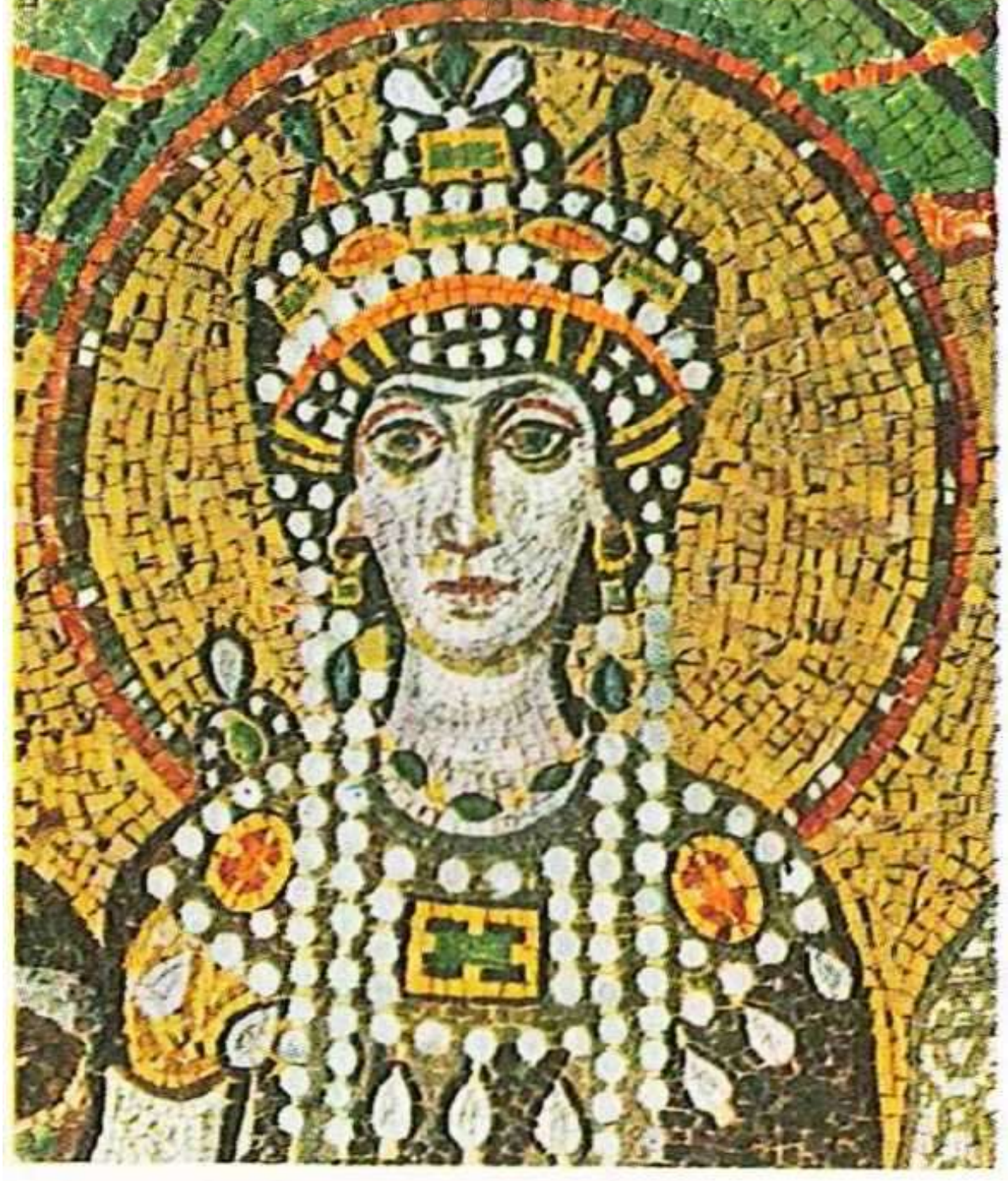
Nave of the Romanesque church of Vezelay. Burgundy, France. 12th century



Nave of the abbey church of Fontevrault, Loire, France
12th century

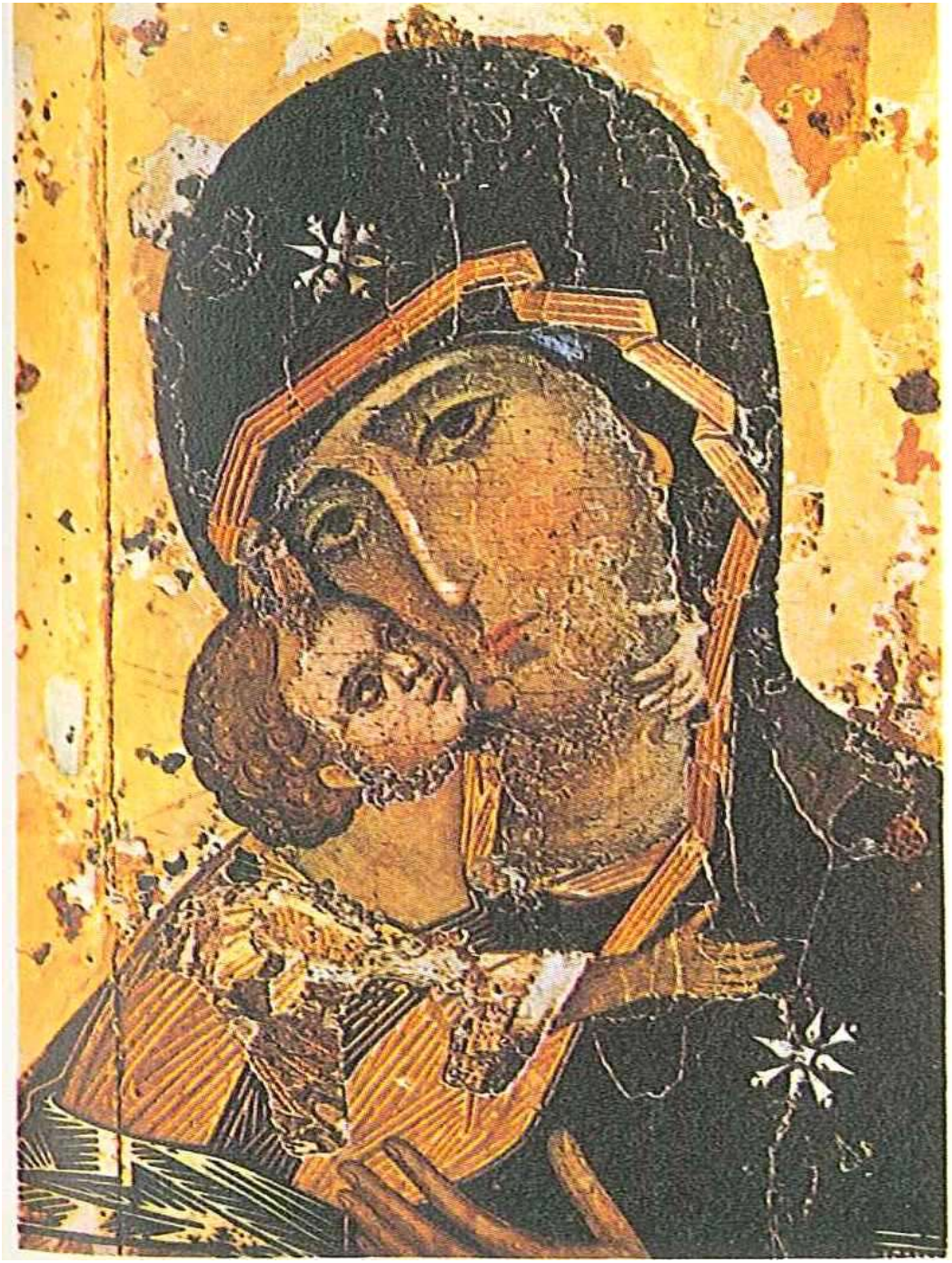


Notre-Dame Cathedral,
Tournai, Belgium,
12th century



Mosaic:

Empress Theodora in San Vitale, Ravenna, Northern Italy about 546 AD



**Virgin of Vladimir,
Moscow,
11th Century painted
in Constantinople**

From Romanesque to **Gothic**

(500-1500 AD)

(early and mid-Medieval to late Medieval)

Medieval
Gothic

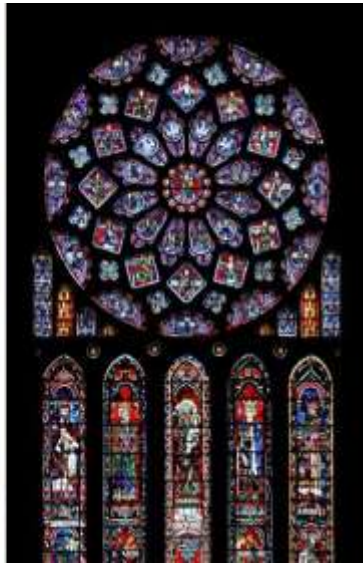
歌德式 architecture
12th-16th century

- ***Pointed arch,***
- ***Ribbed vault,***
- ***Flying buttress,***
- ***Stained glass,***
- ***Very high***







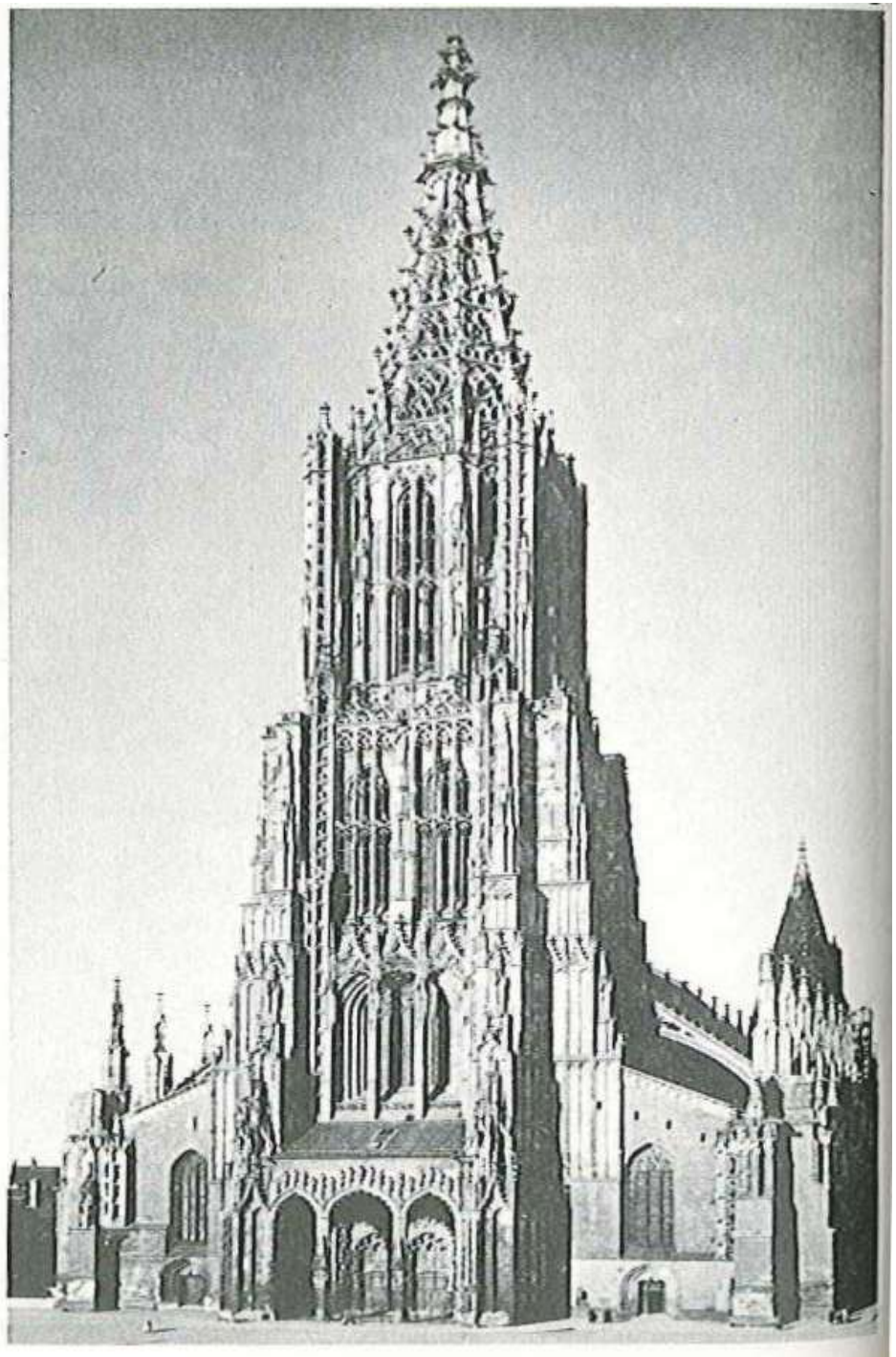




Notre Dame Cathedral, Paris. 1163-1345







Ulm Cathedral, Germany,

14th-15th century

Gothic style





Cologne Cathedral (*Kölner Dom,* Germany),
13th-16th century







Horse and Rider,
Magdeburg, Germany
13th Century



Ilelma assidua alla-
Tota cantetur
ante psalmu
intonationē.
psalmus. Laudate dom
ad sī- Ū
nū omīs gentes. evovae. anth. Cl
pere ante sabbatū que lucescit ī pma
sabbati uenit maria magdalene et
altera maria uidere sepulchrum alle
luia. ad cōple H
ia- cū- mag'. evovae. torū- ā- I

Medieval Music (Sacred)

1. Monophonic (1 voice),

- **Chant** : no harmony, free rhythm, unaccompanied, sung in *Latin*

2. Polyphonic 復音音樂 (more than 1 voice):

- Parallel **Organum** 平行調 **:** 2 or more voices,
- Free **Organum**

Medieval Music (Secular俗乐)

- sung in vernacular in modal scale (versus major/minor key) ;
- dance-like rhythmic mode instrumental music (viol, lute, recorder, flute, drums, etc.);

- Minstrels 吟游诗人: poet+singer+composer+instrumentalist+knight:
- France: **troubadour**, trouvère (chanson);
- Germany: Minnesinger, **Meistersinger** (Lied);
- England: madrigals牧歌, motets 经文歌

- Medieval Chant/Gregorian 格里高利圣歌:
- : modal 調式, free rhythm, unaccompanied, Latin text.

- ***Veni Creator Spiritus*** (Come Holy Spirit)
- With text and *neumatic notation*:https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5u7jTuDBgA4
- Cappella Sistina, Vaticana: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IKtXhfxEgpg

Notre Dame de Paris :https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gQGBMl_CGQI with organ

Salve Regina (Hail, Holy Queen)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CAmydVsNMqM

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bA2M8j9Pdig

Papal Mass in St. Peter's Square with organ

- **Early Polyphony 复音音樂**:
- Parallel Organum

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SzlK7TnmyoE&list=PL2zoT8vXhB4_405z9CAmWmKmceCM6UG6b

- **Liturgical drama礼仪剧（forerunner of opera)**:

- Hildegard von Bingen: *Ordo Virtutum* (Order of the Virtues) c.1151 AD
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WBGgRSPyUFQ





European Lute and Dunhuang Pipa
敦煌琵琶

Medieval Songs with *lute and viol*
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_sUggKIc1TA

- **French minstrels 游吟詩人**
- Troubadour & Trouvère music
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Xk1W22yHLJQ 0:46
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GJtLj3nmr_Q 1:01
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vJv3Oz094J8

More Medieval Music

12th century French polyphony Notre Dame School : Hallelujah https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mNMQu5LXaeI

- Medieval music of Spain https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2Ios-NT0fNI
- Brittany, France https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=E8Mf-1A6YtE

Medieval Literature

- *Beowulf*: old English epic poem written in 8th century; a 2007 3D computer-animated fantasy action film;
- Dante Alighieri 但丁: *Divine Comedy (Divina Commedia)*, **Italian** narrative poem written in 1308-1320; *Inferno, Purgatorio, Paradiso*.
- Chaucer乔叟: *Canterbury Tales*, 24 stories written in Middle **English** in 1387-1400 (Poets' Corner, Westminister Abbey, London). Hailed as the Father of English poetry.
- *Nibelungenlied (Song of the Nibelung)* an epic poem written in Middle High **German** in 1200.

The Influence of Latin in nowadays

- ad hoc (to this, for this purpose)
- ad lib, ad libitum (in optional, improvised)
- bona fide (in good faith, genuine)
- carpe diem (seize the day)
- consensus (agreement)
- de facto (in fact)
- exempli gratia (e.g., for example)
- et cetera (etc., and the rest)
- id est (i.e., that is)
- per se (by itself)
- pro bono publico (for the good of the public)
- sine qua non (without which, no)
- vice versa (the other way around)
- Macro-, micro-, homo-, hetero-, poly-, mono-, inter-, ……

Medieval Characteristics

- Christian art of little to no dimension,
- ***Romanesque*** and ***Gothic*** churches with plain interior and vaults,
- ***Byzantine*** (330-1453 AD) ***mosaic***,
- university education in the late Middle Ages led to more pursuit of science,
- flourishing of art and literature,
- more writings in *vernacular* (local language),
- moving towards a climax of **human wisdom and talent**.